

Getting Along

“Please fax those documents across ASAP!”

“Sure thing. Uh...wait! What's the make of your fax machine?”

Thankfully, we need not worry about such unnecessary details as all fax machines use a common standard for data transmission. But left to itself, the tech industry would have made the above conversation sound more familiar than we can ever imagine.

Industry standards are critical as they assure interoperability and compatibility.

Without proper standards, any new technological advancement is limited to a particular product featuring those capabilities.

Take the case of data communications. A few years back Rockwell and 3Com touted different, competing technologies in their modems for pushing transmission speeds to 56 kbps. Without the intervention of the ITU-T in creating the v.90 standard, datacom speeds would have been limited to 33.6 kbps with us being caught in the middle of having to forcefully adopt one technology (based on what our ISP supported) in order to get a speed boost. This in turn would have limited our freedom of switching to another service provider using a competing standard.

In established markets, market leaders, based on their sheer size and the control they exercise, can split or create new standards. For instance, Intel was late in introducing the SSE instruction set for speeding up multimedia applications (AMD was the pioneer with its 3DNow! technology). But owing to Intel's market dominance, AMD is now forced to tout SSE compatibility in its processors as software vendors have adopted the Intel standard.

However, the battle for standards gains momentous proportions when it comes to the adoption of new technologies in an emerging market. The current mess of the rewritable DVD market can be squarely attributed to the lack of any industry standard with two groups trying to lobby their competing technologies to the consumer.

The one-size-fits-all solution then is to have open standards owned by vendor-neutral organisations, which anyone can use and implement. Case in point: if Wi-Fi wasn't a popular open standard, Intel could have easily created another wireless communication technology for Centrino, its next generation mobile processor technology.

It's not too late for companies to realise that open standards are the only way to avoid consumer confusion and drive innovations. Otherwise, we'll be left with the same madness of the rewritable DVD market where infighting and bickering amongst trade groups has virtually sealed the fate of this promising storage technology.

Now we can only hope that DVD's successor, be it Blu-Ray or holographic storage, will not suffer such a fate.



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